

# CHAPTER 7

## CBI TAKES OVER

'*Handcuffing is a formality, sir.*'

In the jeep was a bearded man. He wore a *kada* on his right wrist. Is this the Pakistani the IB officials claimed to have arrested? For a moment I wondered if some espionage had really taken place. But what was this cock-and-bull story about selling drawings of rockets? That cannot be espionage, I comforted myself.

Later I learnt that the bearded man was S K Sharma, the sixth accused. Sharma, a small-time industrialist, was implicated in the case because he was a friend of Chandrasekhar. Sharma had taken Mariam Rasheeda and Fauziyya Hassan to meet former army brigadier Bhasin who helped Fauziyya's daughter Zila Hamadi get a seat in a Bangalore school. Sharma, like me, had nothing to confess, and the IB men had nothing to show as the balance sheet of our interrogation. The others, however, we came to know later, could not stand the torture and had given statements under duress.

The jeep came to Vazhuthakkad, where DIG Siby Mathews's office was located. I looked around and saw the board 'Babu Raj, IPS'. I was taken in, to a hall. When my escorts moved aside, I realised there was a telephone at my arm's length. I had this urge to pick it, dial home and say I am fine. I stopped myself.

I saw circle inspector Jogesh there. I asked him if I can meet Siby Mathews. The instant reply was in the negative. When I insisted that I have to meet him, Jogesh said the officer did not want to meet me.